

used 92 transistors. This prototype later became the MV950, the first commercial transistorised computer and was built in 1959. Seven MV950s were sold.

1954 Silicon And Supercomputers

April: Silicon!

Gordon Teal of Texas Instrument's Semiconductor R&D announced at a Radio Engineers convention that silicon-based junction transistors were in commercial production. As the story goes, Teal was one of the last speakers, and general opinion was that it would take some years to perfect a silicon transistor. When Teal announced that Texas Instruments had perfected



The first ever transistor looked like... *this!* the silicon transistor, he dipped the germanium transistors of the amplifier of a record player in hot oil. The music died out (the transistors could not tolerate the heat). Next, he dipped the same rig, outfitted with silicon transistors, in hot oil. The music played on; the silicon age had well and truly arrived.

Summer of 54: FORTRAN is born

Development work on FORTRAN (FORmula TRANslator) started at IBM. It was the first popular high-level language and is still in use. The first version was completed in 1957; later revisions, most notably in 1977 and 1990, have ensured that the language retained some relevancy in the modern era (concepts like object oriented programming, arrays, and generic programming were added